The Indie Hacker's Playbook: What Actually Works

A data-driven analysis of 1,000 bootstrapped startups revealing which business models generate real revenue.

The Opportunity: A $1B+ Market of Indie Builders

1,000+ Founders

Building profitable businesses without VC funding

The Real Question

Not *whether* indie hacking works - but *which approach* works best for you

$1B+ Market

Bootstrapped businesses generating real, measurable revenue

B2B SaaS Dominates Revenue

3-5x Higher Revenue

B2B SaaS vs. B2C alternatives

Faster Scaling

Companies targeting other businesses scale faster and retain customers longer

Clear Winners

The data doesn't lie - sell to businesses, not consumers

The New Gold Rush

Resume Builders

AI-powered job tools capturing massive demand

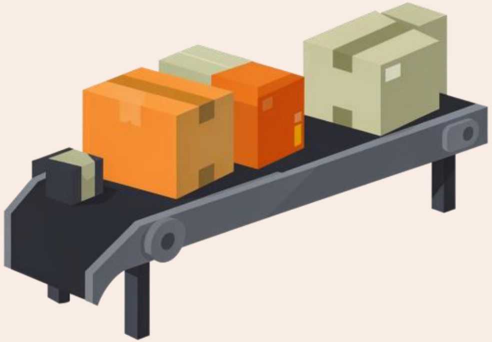
Content Creation

Copy, blog, social - AI tools dominating every format

Explosive Growth

Disproportionate revenue despite saturation concerns

E-commerce & Dropshipping: High Volume, Lower Margins



The Model Works - But Profitability Is in the Details

Platforms like Supliful prove e-commerce is viable at scale. The challenge? **Unit economics** determine everything.

High Volume

Significant gross revenue potential

Constant CAC Pressure

Requires relentless customer acquisition spend

Margin Squeeze

Thin margins punish founders who ignore unit economics

Geographic Arbitrage Still Works

BR **Brazil**

Growing indie ecosystem, lower operational costs, underserved SaaS niches

TR **Turkey**

Strong engineering talent, favorable cost structures, rising builder community

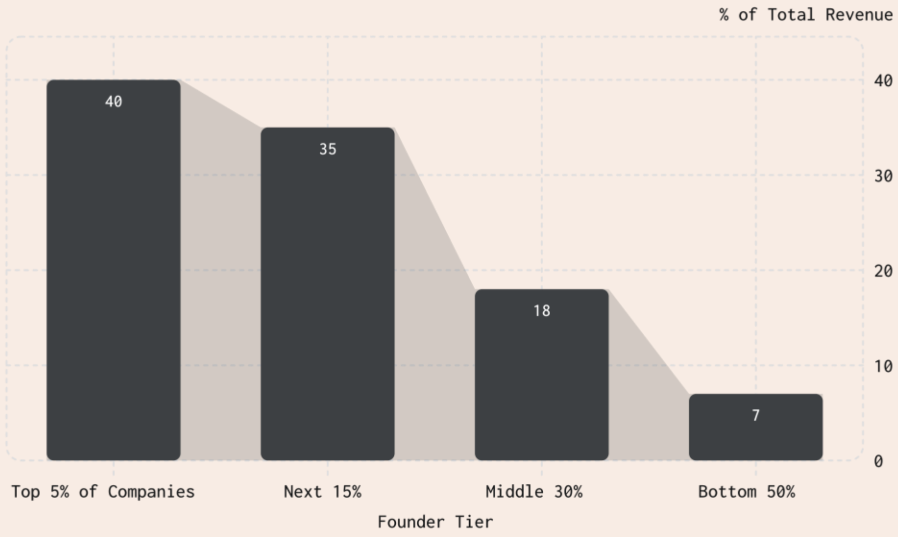
🌍 **Eastern Europe**

Deep technical roots, global-facing products, competitive advantages over Silicon Valley costs

The Revenue Concentration Problem

17.5%

Total conversion rate



What This Means for You

Revenue is brutally concentrated. The top 5% capture 40%+ of all revenue generated across 1,000+ startups.

The implication is simple: pick the right category and business model - or compete in a crowded field with razor-thin margins.

Category selection is the highest-leverage decision a founder makes.

Pricing Models That Win

2–3x

Better Retention

Subscription SaaS vs. one-time purchase models

40%+

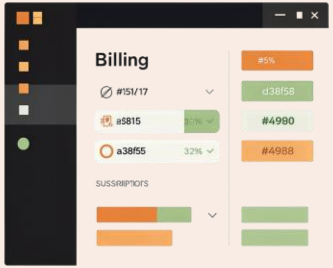
Revenue Predictability

Recurring models provide forecasting advantages transactional models can't match

#1

Subscription Wins

The clear top-performing pricing structure across all categories in the dataset



One-Time vs. Recurring

Transactional models create a **revenue treadmill** - you stop selling. Subscription flips that equation, compounding growth over time.

- Monthly recurring revenue smooths cash flow
- Annual plans improve retention dramatically

Your Move: Three Paths Forward

Path 1 - High Risk, High Reward

Build AI tools targeting B2B SaaS. Saturated but proven. Winners take disproportionate revenue. You need differentiation and speed.

Path 2 - Steady Growth

B2B service tools with subscription pricing. Less sexy, far more stable. Boring businesses compound quietly into life-changing revenue.

Path 3 - Emerging Opportunity

Geographic arbitrage in underserved markets. Lower competition, lower costs. Build where Silicon Valley isn't looking.